

Saracoff Sentinel / Team Tijuana

Spring 2009



Keep on Keepin' On by Greg Saracoff

Points for Prayer

- Strength for Josefina to organize her business so it will help support her ministry.
- Ministry leaders to balance work and family time; discernment as they face overwhelming needs.
- For the Carretas project among poor children that we will find new ways to reach out and involve the community in the project.
- God's healing touch on broken families; may his love flow through us to others who are hurting.
- For an outreach to youth that will extend to those tempted to join gangs.
- A car to replace one that was stolen from Kathy's friend Elie

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Let us hear from you!

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"Keep on keepin' on..." I always disliked sayings like this one or its brother: "Keep your nose to the grindstone." These sayings have merit but seem to stifle the joyful, exploring, risk-taking side of me.

Tuesdays in our Team TJ meetings we have been memorizing and studying Romans 5:1-5. Verse 2 expresses the great joy and hope we have when we stretch our minds to the future, when our Lord will glorify our bodies and we will be like Him. "Hot Dog!" But what about verse 3: "we rejoice in our sufferings"? Somehow I **knew** that would be in there.

Our character needs ex-

ercise as badly as our bodies do. The muscle we develop by our faithful continuance in hard times is adding to our spiritual biceps of "hope."

Some current areas where our ministries are exercising can be seen on the next page. You have heard of some of these needs before--we ask you to continue on in your prayers and support as we wait on the Lord.

Verse 3 says "Rejoice!" **God can do it!** So as you struggle in your own lives and pray also for Mexico, we wish you the Lord's peace. But don't stop there. What about the joy? They say, "Joy is peace dancing." So let's kick it up a notch.



ROMANS 5:2-5

²And we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God. ³Not only so, but we also rejoice in our sufferings, because we know that suffering produces perseverance; ⁴perseverance, character; and character, hope. ⁵And hope does not disappoint us, because God has poured out His love into our hearts by the Holy Spirit, whom He has given us. "



Beauty amid squalor: Chela threw a surprise "Quinceñera" in **Carretas** for Judith and Elizabeth. Celebrating the 15th year is an important rite of passage in this culture. Their families could never have afforded it. Carretas, at the foot of the old dump, is the site for the community center we're building.

From Washington to Tijuana: Reflections By Carolyn Bickford

Tijuana has gotten lots of press lately, mostly bad and sensationalized. So how refreshing to have Carolyn Bickford show up on our doorstep, all the way from the state of Washington, ready to live a week in Tijuana. In fact, of **all** the places in the world she could have gone, Tijuana topped her list! She shared her sewing, gardening, nursing and teaching skills, with creativity, care and love. Her Spanish came in handy, too! She writes....



"I stepped out of my comfort zone to see what God is doing in Tijuana. My trip included so many unexpected blessings. Picture children holding me by the hand so I wouldn't fall on the steep and slippery foot paths. Picture Christians celebrating God's goodness even though their city is full of fear and uncertainty because of the "sequestraciones" (kidnappings) taking place and the lack of tourist revenues. Picture donated purchases of food supplies being served with love to people of all ages and situations. Picture people who have strong faith reaching out to the handicapped, the hungry, the disabled, the drug-addicted, the homeless, the ancient, the lonely."

The Saracoffs gave me entry into their ministry sites and interpreted the social dynamics and introduced me to people they have worked with for many years. What I heard from these people was praise for God and His work in their lives and their respect and appreciation for Greg and Kathy."

← Women at Esperanza Rehab learned from Carolyn how to grow (and eat!) nutritious sprouts.

Updates on Team Tijuana Ministries...

El Refugio—Home for the Elderly houses over 130 "abuelos" and has an overdue electric bill for over a \$500 USD. The whole place needs to be rewired, and a transformer purchased to reduce the monthly costs.

El Camino Josefina was selling donuts to people on the streets using some of the women she was helping at her home for abused women. We helped her rent a store front to expand the donut production and raise funds for her ministry. The business is struggling but they are trying to get contracts to sell to nearby factories.

Esperanza Drug Rehab has made plans to rejuvenate their stain glass, block building, and welding shop, incorporating them into vocational training. We are getting a loan for this expansion. A Korean church recently supplied funding for the sound system and instruments for the new chapel!

Campo de Fe has a new member dog! Peppy needed some rehab and lots of TLC. He and the 8-10 disabled men are thriving under Flor's care.



Baseball Camp High school seniors Steven Halcomb & Austin Steussy put on an amazing one-day event April 18 to teach kids baseball. They and their teammates (and a few parents) brought gear, food, caps and shirts to give to 100 kids from several different parts of Tijuana. A hot dog lunch and a Gospel presentation concluded their big day. This began last year as a senior project and the legacy looks like it will continue as others step up to the plate to lead. Thanks, Ryan, for last year's vision!

